



The Speed-to-Lead Playbook for Real Estate

How AI Voice Agents Turn Missed Calls Into Booked
Appointments

An Industry Guide by Stellar Voice Agents

stellarvoiceagents.com · June 2026

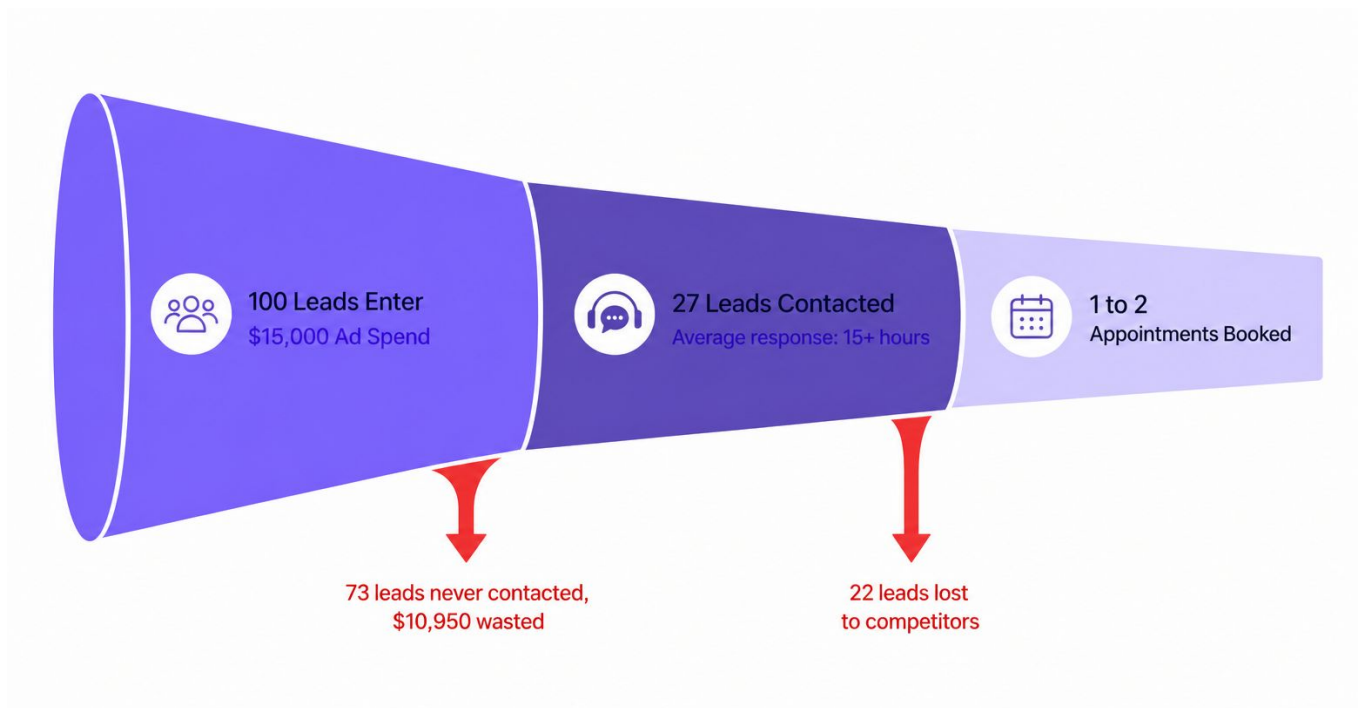
The \$23,000 Problem

The average real estate commission in the US is \$11,723 per side (Clever Real Estate, May 2026). Every lead that slips through the cracks is not a minor inconvenience. It is a five-figure loss walking out the door.

Real estate agents spend \$100 to \$300+ per lead on platforms like Google Ads and Zillow (WordStream 2025, Zillow 2026). The industry conversion rate from lead to client sits between 0.4% and 1.2%. Only 27% of leads are ever contacted after being captured. The culprit is simple: the average agent takes over 15 hours to respond to a new inquiry (Inman 2025 Technology Survey).

You are paying \$100 to \$300 per lead. Then you take 15 hours to call them back. By then, 78% have already hired someone else.

Sources: WordStream 2025, Inman 2025 Technology Survey, Clever Real Estate May 2026



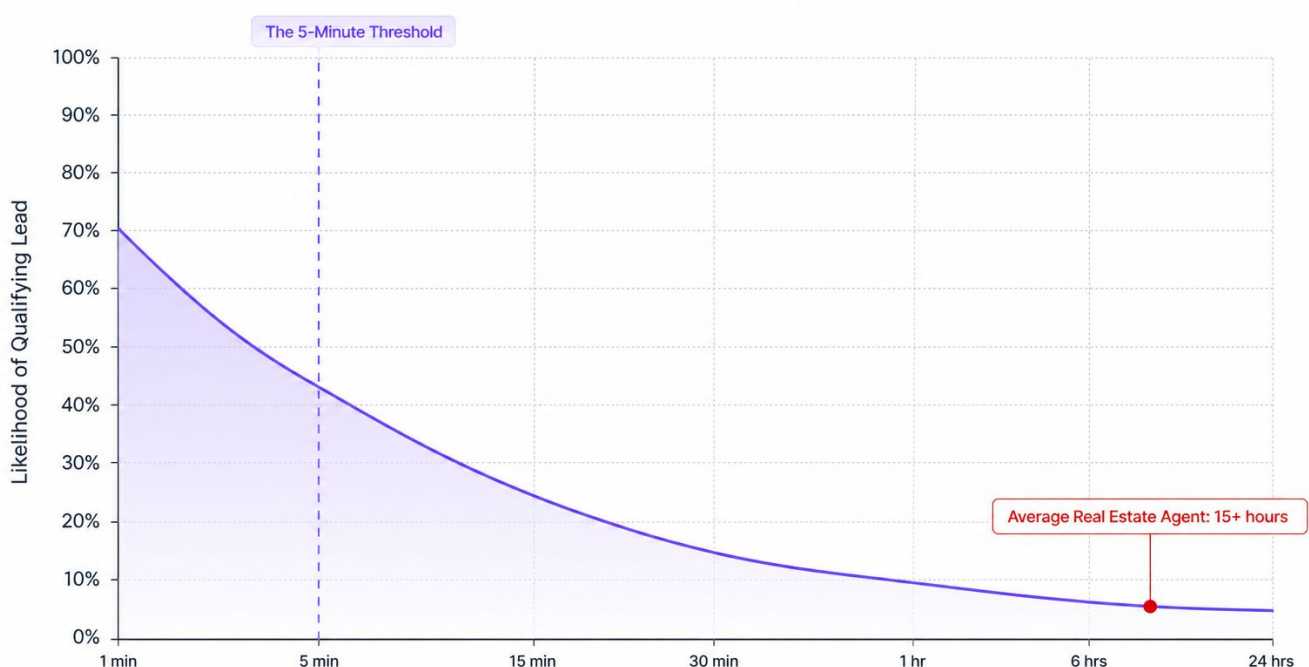
The 5-Minute Rule

In 2011, Harvard Business Review published a landmark study by Oldroyd, McElheran, and Elkington. The researchers examined 2,241 US companies and over 100,000 web-generated leads. The finding was unambiguous: firms that respond within 5 minutes are 100x more likely to connect with the lead and 21x more likely to qualify them compared to firms that wait 30 minutes.

Velocify (2012) found that responding at 1 minute versus 2 minutes improves the contact rate by 391%. After 5 minutes, lead quality drops by 80% (InsideSales.com). The pattern is consistent across every study: speed is not a nice-to-have. It is the single largest determinant of whether a lead converts.

100x more likely to connect. 21x more likely to qualify. The data is not ambiguous.

Sources: Harvard Business Review (Oldroyd et al., 2011), Velocify 2012, InsideSales.com



The Real Estate Response Gap

The research is clear on what works: respond in under 5 minutes, make 8 to 12 follow-up attempts, and cover leads that arrive after hours. But the real estate industry operates in the opposite direction.

917 min average response time

48% of inquiries go unanswered

27% of leads ever contacted

Most agents quit follow-up after 1 to 2 attempts. Yet research shows it takes 8 to 12 follow-up attempts to convert an internet lead, and 80% of closed sales require five or more contact touches (NAR). Meanwhile, 40% of qualified inquiries arrive outside business hours (CallRail/Ringba) and go completely unworked until the next business day.

Sources: Inman 2025, NAR 2025, CallRail/Ringba, industry benchmarks

What the Research Says	What Most Agents Do
 Respond in under 5 minutes	 Respond in 15+ hours
 Make 8 to 12 follow-up attempts	 Quit after 1 to 2 attempts
 Cover after-hours leads, 40% of volume	 No after-hours coverage
 Contact 100% of leads	 Contact only 27% of leads

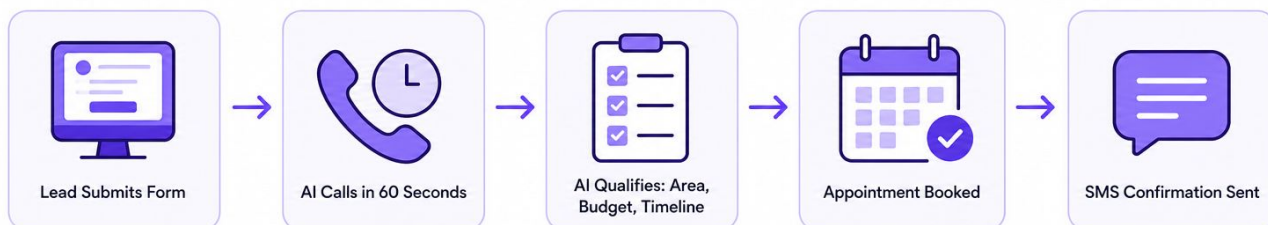
What AI Voice Agents Actually Do

An AI voice agent is not a chatbot. It is a real-time voice conversation that sounds and feels human. When a lead fills out a form, the AI calls them back within 60 seconds. It does not wait for business hours. It does not take a lunch break. It does not call in sick.

The 60-Second Response Process

Three Things to Understand

1. This is a voice conversation, not a chatbot. The lead speaks naturally. The AI listens, responds, and qualifies in real time. EasyStart Homes' client reaction: "That's just so unreal, well done!"
2. The AI qualifies and books. It does not sell. It captures the minimum viable information: area of interest, budget range, timeline. Then it books the right appointment with the right agent. Deep discovery is the agent's job.
3. It works 24/7/365. No breaks, no training ramp-up, no sick days. Every lead gets a callback within 60 seconds, whether it arrives at 2pm Tuesday or 11pm Saturday.



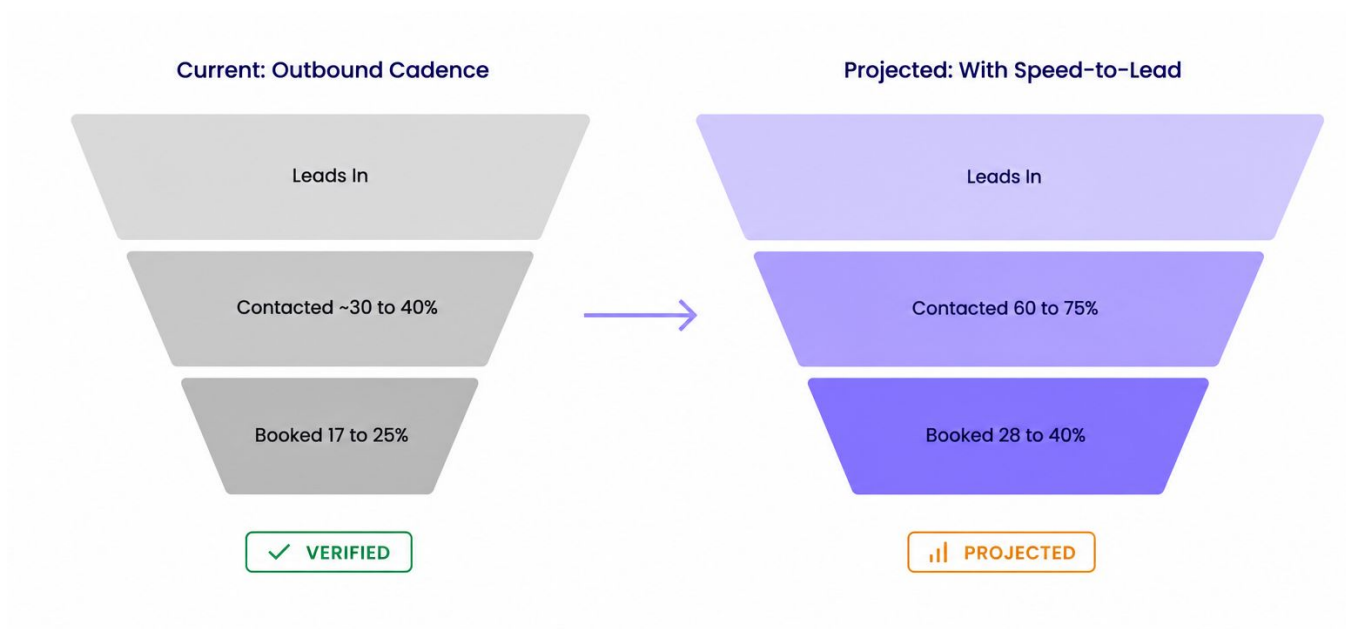
Real Results: EasyStart Homes

EasyStart Homes is an Australian home builder. Sales consultant Denes Aldott needed a way to contact and qualify inbound leads without burning hours on the phone. SVA deployed an outbound calling cadence: 9 touches across 6 days, blending calls, SMS, and email.

17-25% sustained booking rate. VERIFIED, 6 months live.

Zero human caller hours required.

PROJECTION: Adding speed-to-lead, an instant callback within 60 seconds, targets two mechanisms: a higher first-attempt contact rate (from ~30 to 40% up to ~60 to 75%) and capture of after-hours leads (35 to 50% of volume). Conservative projection: 28 to 35% booking rate. Moderate: 32 to 40%. At 75 leads per month, this models 8 to 11 additional qualified bookings per month.

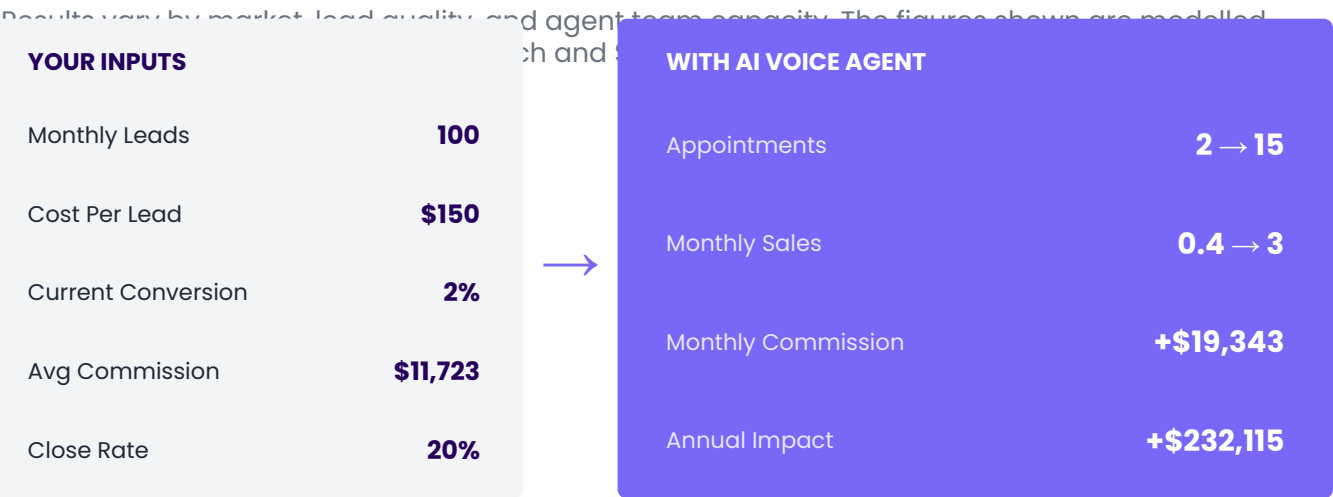


The ROI Model for Your Agency

The numbers below use conservative inputs based on published industry benchmarks. Your actual numbers will vary by market, lead source, and team capacity. The model demonstrates one thing clearly: the AI does not need to be perfect. It just needs to be faster and more persistent than a human team that takes 15 hours to respond and quits after 2 attempts.

At a 15% lead-to-appointment conversion rate, 100 leads per month generates 15 qualified appointments instead of 2. At a 20% close rate and \$11,723 average commission, that is an additional \$232,115 in annual commission from the same ad spend. SVA's EasyStart Homes client currently achieves a 17 to 25% booking rate, exceeding the 15% used in this model.

What would 10 extra qualified appointments per month mean for your business? At your average commission, how many additional sales would it take to justify this investment?



Performance-Based Pricing

Most AI voice solutions charge a monthly retainer regardless of whether the system delivers results. SVA works differently. SVA charges a retainer that covers operational costs, plus a performance fee per qualified appointment delivered. SVA earns when you earn. If the AI does not book appointments, SVA does not profit.

How the Alternatives Compare

The difference is structural. An ISA costs \$45,000 to \$65,000 per year in salary alone, works 40 hours per week, needs training, and calls in sick. An outsourced call centre runs \$2,000 to \$5,000 per month with inconsistent quality and limited hours. Retainer-model AI charges \$500 to \$1,500 per month whether or not it produces a single appointment. SVA's model ties payment to performance. The incentives are identical to yours.

We do not charge you to try. We charge you when it works.

	Hire ISA	Call Centre	AI (Retainer)	SVA (Performance)
Cost	\$45K to \$65K/yr	\$2K to \$5K/mo	\$500 to \$1.5K/mo	Retainer + per booking
Availability	40 hrs/week	Business hours	24/7	24/7/365
Risk	You pay regardless	You pay regardless	You pay regardless	SVA carries risk
Scalability	Hire more staff	Pay more	Included	Included

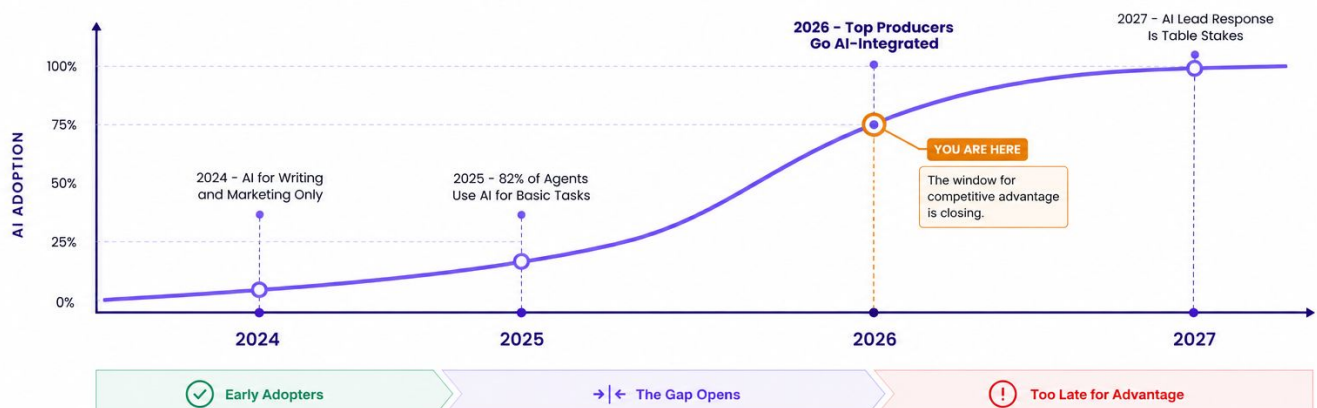
The Window Is Closing

82% of real estate agents now use AI in some form (RPR, 2025). But most use it for writing listing descriptions or generating social media content. Almost none use it for the one thing that matters most: responding to leads before the competition does.

88% of real estate investors have started piloting AI across an average of 5 use cases (JLL). But 60%+ of companies remain stuck in the pilot trap, running demos without scaling into production (PwC/WEF 2026). The agents who deploy AI for lead response now will capture the leads that slower agents lose.

AI voice agents do not replace real estate agents. 88% of buyers still use an agent (NAR 2025). AI replaces the 15-hour wait that loses the deal before any agent gets involved.

By the end of 2026, the majority of top-producing agents are expected to operate within AI-integrated environments. By 2027, AI-powered lead response will be table stakes. The question is not whether you will adopt this. The question is whether you adopt it while it still provides a competitive advantage, or after everyone else already has.



Your Next Step

Three things are true:

- 1 Speed wins. The first agent to respond gets the deal 78% of the time. The research is unanimous on this point.
- 2 The gap is massive. Your industry averages 15+ hours to respond. AI responds in 60 seconds. That is not an incremental improvement. It is a structural advantage.
- 3 The risk is aligned. SVA's pricing model means you pay a retainer that covers costs, plus a performance fee per qualified appointment delivered. SVA earns when you earn.

See it in action. Book a 15-minute demo and hear what your leads will hear.

Not ready for a demo? Reply to the email that delivered this guide and ask us anything. A real human will respond. Know another agent or team leader who should read this? Forward this guide.



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Demo

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